

A COMPENDIUM OF THE TIMELESS GAMES OF HUMANKIND

The *Timeless* Board

*A journey through Chess, Bao, and Ajua —
from ancient courts to the hearths of the Iteso people*



KENYA • UGANDA • TANZANIA

WRITTEN IN THE SPIRIT OF THE ITESO PEOPLE · EAST AFRICA · UGANDA · KENYA

DEDICATED TO OUR DEAR FATHER, H.E.

BY YOUR CHILDREN: LIDONG'A, OSIER & ILEJJE

A GIFT

For

H.E.

*Three games. One board. A lifetime of moves
made in your shadow, and in your light. This
book is the record of what you taught us —
that how you play says who you are.*

"Aibokin ijo aipara ka ateker."

The one who knows the old ways is never lost.

FROM LIDONG'A, OSIER & ILEJJE

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WRITTEN IN THE SPIRIT OF THE ITESO PEOPLE

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Through Iteso Eyes

Before we walk through the histories of these three great games, we pause — as the Iteso elder pauses before speaking — to ground ourselves in the world from which this book is told. The Iteso, a Nilotic people straddling eastern Uganda and western Kenya, have been keepers of profound traditions of strategy, community, and wisdom for centuries. Their perspective infuses this entire volume.

The Iteso organise themselves through a clan system — originally nine clans, from which all later clans are said to have broken off. Each clan bears its own identity and role. The *Ikaribwok* (also known as *Ikaruok*) were the battle-hardened warriors and fighters — the largest clan, whose name literally means "those who make sounds of victory after winning a battle." The *Inomu* were the medical clan — healers and bone-setters whose expertise in medicine determined whether warriors lived or died. The *Igoria*, named after the humble hooded finch bird, were architects and builders. The *Irarak* were the hunters and gatherers who fed the people.

Each clan had a head called the *Apolon ka Ateker*, elected at a ceremony known as *Airukorin*. The person chosen was always of three qualities: bravery, neutrality, and intelligence — the same qualities required of any great chess player. His

inauguration involved the ceremonial opening of a road that had been deliberately blocked for two weeks — a powerful symbol: leadership is the clearing of the way.

Akogo — The Thumb Piano

The akogo, crafted from bamboo tubes of varying lengths, is the defining instrument of the Iteso — played with thumbs and forefingers. It sets the rhythm for the Akogo dance, performed at weddings, funerals, births of twins, and celebrations. Like a chess clock, it marks the pace of life's most important moments.

Ekiria Kiria

Among the most celebrated Iteso traditional dances. Performers move in circular formation, each taking their turn at the centre. This democratic rotation mirrors the philosophy of Bao and Ajua: every player — and every pawn — has their moment.

The Emorimor

In 1995, the Iteso people of Uganda installed their first king in modern memory — the *Emorimor*. His authority rests not on force alone but on the trust and cultural standing of his people. In the personalised chess set later in this book, the King piece represents exactly this.

Traditional Dress

During ceremonies, Iteso men wear colourful *shukas* and headdresses of animal skins and feathers. Women traditionally wore *barkcloth*, while young girls wore the *itibire* — beaded garments decorated with *arobai* — intricate patterns in which every bead placement carries meaning.

Cattle & Wealth

Among the Iteso, wealth was measured in cattle, land, and food. Bridewealth was negotiated with sticks representing cows; the number agreed before the cattle were brought. This tangible, relational economy directly connects to Ajua, where the original stakes were precisely this: cattle, goats, and standing in the community.

The Ipara

The spirits of the dead — the *Ipara* — do not merely watch from a distance. They are believed to inhabit and influence the living. Special dances, accompanied by rattles and the *emudiri* drum, were held to invoke ancestors for consultation. Every elder who once taught Ajua is, in this sense, an Ipara — a presence that moves pieces long after they have left the board.

"Aibokin ijo aipara ka ateker."

An Iteso saying: *"The one who knows the old ways is never lost."*

— This book is an act of knowing.

PART ONE

Chess

The Game of Kings — from India to the digital age



C H A P T E R · O n e

Origins in India — Chaturanga

Before 600 AD

Every great thing begins with a story. The Iteso say that the ancestors of their people came from Abyssinia — from the high plateaus of Ethiopia, moving south through Karamoja before settling their vast homeland. Chess has its own origin story, equally ancient and equally filled with migration and transformation.

The earliest known ancestor of chess was born in northern India during the Gupta Empire. It was called *Chaturanga* — Sanskrit for "four limbs" of an army: infantry, cavalry, elephants, and chariots. The board on which it was played — the ashtapada, an 8×8 grid — was already ancient, originally used for racing games.



ITESO PARALLEL

The Clan as Army

The Iteso originally organised their society into nine clans, each with a distinct role — healers (Inomu), warriors (Ikaribwok), builders (Igoria), hunters (Irarak) — every group serving the whole in a specialised capacity.

Chaturanga's four divisions of an army mirror this exactly: each piece type a different function, each essential to the survival of the whole.

Piece	Original Name	Movement	Modern Equivalent
 Raja	Raja (King)	One square any direction	King
 Mantri	Mantri (Minister)	One square diagonally	Queen (weak form)
 Gaja	Gaja (Elephant)	Two squares diagonally, jumping	Bishop
 Ashva	Ashva (Horse)	L-shape — identical to today's Knight	Knight
 Ratha	Ratha (Chariot)	Any squares orthogonally	Rook
 Padati	Padati (Foot soldier)	Forward one; captures diagonally	Pawn

The earliest clear written reference to Chaturanga comes from the Persian text *Chatrang-namak* (around 600 AD), which describes how an Indian king sent the game to the Persian court as a diplomatic gift — a move of intellectual

statecraft that the Iteso Apolon ka Ateker, with his emphasis on wisdom and neutrality, would have applauded.

C H A P T E R · T w o

Persia and the Islamic Golden Age

600 – 800 AD

When Chaturanga arrived in Persia, it shed its Sanskrit skin and became *Chatrang*, then — after the Islamic conquest of Persia in the seventh century — *Shatranj*. Islamic scholars embraced it as a tool for logical thinking and military strategy. The pieces were rendered as abstract shapes, following Islamic aniconism. The Elephant became *pil*; the Chariot became *rukḥ*, from the mythical Roc bird; the Queen (*firzān*, the counsellor) moved only one square diagonally — slow and deliberate, like an elder advising a chief.

THE FIRST MASTER

As-Suli — A Name Worth Knowing

Abu Bakr Muhammad bin Yahya al-Suli (9th century AD) was perhaps the first genius of chess. His manuals on endgame positions and tactical combinations were so advanced that players would say of a difficult position: "Only As-Suli could solve this." He is the game's first known

theorist — the equivalent of the Apolon ka Ateker who not only governed but codified the law.

Islamic scholars also developed the *mansubat* — elaborate chess puzzle positions that became a high art form — and the first recorded blindfold chess game was played in the Islamic world, a feat of spatial memory that still astonishes today.

C H A P T E R · Three

Chess Enters Europe

9th – 14th Century

Chess travelled to Europe along two great highways of civilisation. The first was the Moorish conquest of Spain in 711 AD. The second was the Silk Road and Mediterranean trade routes, which brought it to Italy and Byzantium. By the 11th century, chess was played from the libraries of Córdoba to the cold halls of Norse Scandinavia.

Europeans gave the pieces figurative shapes: kings with crowns, bishops with mitres, rooks as castle towers. Two critical new rules emerged in this period to speed up the opening of the game.

13th Century

The **pawn double-step** — a pawn on its starting square may advance two squares on its first move, accelerating the opening contest for the centre.

Late 13th – 14th Century

En passant is introduced as a counter to the double-step — a capturing rule unlike any other in chess, preserving tactical fairness.

~1000 AD

The famous **Lewis Chessmen** — 93 pieces carved from walrus ivory in the Norse or Scottish isles — are among the most beautiful surviving medieval chess sets in the world.

C H A P T E R · F o u r

The "Mad Queen" Revolution

Late 15th Century

Around 1475–1500, in Spain or Italy, something extraordinary happened. The two slowest pieces on the board — the Queen and the Bishop — received devastating new powers. The Queen could now move any number of squares in any direction. The Bishop could slide the full diagonal length of the board. Chess would never be the same.

The game was called *scacchi alla rabiosa* — "mad chess" — or *alla regina*, "queen's chess." The Iteso might have recognised it as a game that now rewarded those qualities their Apolon ka Ateker was chosen for: bold intelligence, the ability to move swiftly across the full terrain of the community's affairs, and the wisdom to use that power without squandering it.

1497 M I L E S T O N E

The First Printed Chess Book

In 1497, the Spanish priest Luis Ramírez de Lucena published *Repetición de Amores y Arte de Ajedrez* — the

earliest known printed chess manual under the new rules. It contained the first recorded opening lines. In Iteso terms, the Airukorin ceremony had been held, the Apolon ka Ateker had spoken, and the rules were henceforth for all clans to follow.

C H A P T E R · Five

Standardisation

16th - 19th Century

Two final rules completed chess's modern form.

Castling — evolved from a medieval "king's leap" into the refined two-square manoeuvre — was formalised in Italy around 1600. **Stalemate** was universally defined as a draw: the side that cannot move without entering check is not the loser but draws. Powerlessness, in chess, earns half a point — a philosophical curiosity that has fascinated players ever since.

Howard Staunton (1810-1874), the great English champion, organised the first international tournament in London in 1851 and designed the standardised chess pieces that bear his name — the **Staunton pattern** — still used in all official play worldwide today.

C H A P T E R · S i x

The Modern Era — Champions and Computers

1886 – Present

1886

Wilhelm Steinitz defeats Johannes Zukertort to become the first official World Chess Champion, and fathers modern positional play — the idea that small advantages accumulate into decisive wins.

1921 – 1927

José Raúl Capablanca of Cuba — perhaps the most naturally gifted player of all time — holds the world title, before losing it to the fierce Alexander Alekhine in one of the great upsets of chess history.

1945 – 1990s

The Soviet Union dominates chess, producing champions of extraordinary depth: Botvinnik, Tal (the "Magician from Riga"), Petrosian, Spassky, Karpov, and Kasparov.

1972

Bobby Fischer of the USA defeats Boris Spassky in Reykjavik, Iceland — the "Match of the Century," watched by millions at the height of the Cold War.

1997

IBM's Deep Blue defeats Garry Kasparov in a six-game match — the first time a machine defeats a reigning world

champion under tournament conditions. A watershed for artificial intelligence.



2024

Dommaraju Gukesh of India — born in 2006 — becomes the youngest World Chess Champion in history, defeating Ding Liren of China. A new era begins.

Today, AI engines like Stockfish, AlphaZero, and Leela Chess Zero play far beyond human level — yet millions play chess daily on Chess.com and Lichess, drawn by the same thing that drew an Indian king to send a board to the Persian court fifteen centuries ago: the pure pleasure of contest.

How to Play Chess

THE STARTING POSITION

Chess is played on an 8×8 board of 64 squares, alternating light and dark. Two players — one commanding the light pieces, one the dark — alternate moves. The aim is to trap the opponent's King in a position from which it cannot escape: **checkmate**.

Setting Up the Board

- 1 Place the board so each player has a light square at their near-right corner ("light on right").
- 2 In each player's back rank: Rooks in the corners, Knights beside them, Bishops beside the Knights, then Queen on her own colour, King on the remaining central square.
- 3 Fill the entire second rank with Pawns — eight per side.

4

White always moves first. Players alternate turns thereafter.

How Each Piece Moves

Piece	Movement	Special Rule
 King	One square in any direction	Can castle once per game
 Queen	Any number of squares in any direction	Most powerful piece
 Rook	Any number of squares horizontally or vertically	Participates in castling
 Bishop	Any number of squares diagonally	Always stays on its starting colour
 Knight	L-shape: two squares one way, one square perpendicular	Only piece that jumps over others
 Pawn	Forward one square (or two on first move); captures diagonally	En passant; promotes on reaching the 8th rank

Key Rules

- 1 **Check:** When the King is directly threatened, the player in check must immediately resolve it — by moving the King, blocking, or capturing the attacking piece.
- 2 **Checkmate:** When the King is in check and has no legal escape — the checkmated player loses.
- 3 **Castling:** The King slides two squares toward a Rook; that Rook jumps to the other side. Neither may have moved; the King may not castle through or into check.
- 4 **Promotion:** A Pawn reaching the opponent's back rank is immediately promoted to any piece — almost always a Queen.
- 5 **Stalemate:** If a player has no legal moves but is not in check, the game is a draw. Powerlessness without danger is not defeat — it is standstill.

Control the Centre

The four central squares (e4, d4, e5, d5) are the heart of the board. A piece in the centre controls more squares and operates with greater power. Fight for the centre with pawns and minor pieces in the opening.

Develop Your Pieces

In the opening, every move should bring a new piece into the game — Knights and Bishops before repeated Queen moves. An undeveloped army is a sleeping army.

Protect Your King

Castle early. Bring your King to safety behind a wall of pawns. An exposed King in the centre is a constant liability that your opponent will exploit throughout the entire game.

Piece Activity

A Bishop blocked by its own pawns is worth far less than a Knight posted on an outpost deep in enemy territory. Evaluate not just material count but the activity and coordination of every piece.

Pawn Structure

Doubled pawns, isolated pawns, and passed pawns shape the long-term character of any position. A sound pawn structure in the endgame often decides the result when all the pieces are gone.

The Endgame

Most beginners neglect endgame technique. A King becomes powerful here — centralise it. Rook endgames and the ability to

convert a slight material advantage separate the good from the great.

T HE GREAT CHAMPIONS

9TH CENTURY AD



As-Suli

The Arab master whose endgame studies remained unsurpassed for a thousand years. The first chess theorist.

1886 – 1894



Wilhelm Steinitz

First official World Champion. Founder of modern positional play — the science of accumulated small advantages.

1921 – 1927



José Capablanca

Cuban genius with almost supernatural intuition. His endgame technique remains a model of clarity and economy.

1960 – 1961



Mikhail Tal

The "Magician from Riga" — famous for dazzling sacrificial attacks that defied classical rules. Chess as pure art.

1985 – 2000



Garry Kasparov

Widely considered the greatest of all time. His preparation, intelligence, and competitive fire were unmatched.

2024 – PRESENT



D. Gukesh

The youngest world champion in history at 18 — India's new standard-bearer for a new generation of chess.

PART TWO

Bao

The Grand Sowing Game of East Africa



The Ancient Roots — Mancala and the Cradle of Games

Long before India gave us Chaturanga, Africa was already playing. The mancala family of games — whose name derives from the Arabic *naqala*, meaning "to move" — encompasses hundreds of variants played with seeds, stones, or shells in pits carved from wood or dug directly into the earth. The Iteso know well that the earth remembers everything. And the earth of East Africa has held the memory of these games for at least seven thousand years.

Archaeological evidence — pit depressions carved into ancient rock across Ethiopia, Kenya, Uganda, and Tanzania — suggests counting and sowing games as old as the earliest agricultural settlements in the region. Around 1400 BC, Egyptians carved mancala boards into the stone floors of temples at Karnak and into the pyramids at El-Lahun. These were not games for common folk — they were played in sacred spaces. Strategy was holy.



From the Nile to the Coast

From the Nile valley, mancala spread along trade routes, across the Sahara, and down the East African coast through Bantu migrations and the Swahili trade network. Every community that received it made it their own. And nowhere was it made more magnificently complex than along the shores of the Indian Ocean.

The Birth of Bao in Swahili Culture

Before the 17th Century

Bao — the Swahili word for "board" — is not merely a mancala game. It is the most complex mancala game ever devised. The board: four rows of eight pits — 32 pits in total. Two players each control two rows: the front (attack) row and the back (store) row. Seeds — traditionally real seeds, stones, or shells — are the pieces. The sowing mechanic, capturing chains, and the strict rule that a capturing move must always be taken when available combine into a game of extraordinary strategic depth.

THE BAO BOARD — 4 ROWS × 8 PITS

North player's rows (top) · South player's rows (bottom) · Front rows face inward

Feature	Description
Board	4 rows × 8 pits = 32 pits total
Seeds	64 seeds total — 32 per player at the start

Feature	Description
Control	Each player controls 2 rows (front attack row + back store row)
Capturing	Mandatory when available — you must capture if you can
Victory	Opponent cannot make a valid move, or has fewer than 2 seeds in their front row
The Nyumba	A "house" — a special pit built over several turns, granting tactical advantages and protections

First Written Evidence — Muyaka bin Haji

Early 1800s

The earliest clear literary reference to Bao comes from the poetry of Muyaka bin Haji (1776–1840), the celebrated poet of Mombasa, Kenya. In his verses, he describes gameplay with specific Bao terminology — *nyumba* (houses), *kibao* (board), the act of "eating" seeds — confirming that a fully recognisable form of modern Bao was played on the Kenyan coast in the early 19th century. The oldest surviving physical Bao board dates to 1896, from Malawi (where the game is called Bawo), and is now housed in the British Museum.

AN ITESO PARALLEL

Poetry as Documentation

The Iteso preserved their history through oral tradition — stories, songs, and proverbs passed from elder to grandchild by firelight. The Apolon ka Ateker was chosen in part for his memory of such oral records. Muyaka bin Haji's preservation of Bao through poetry is this same tradition at work. When the Iteso say "Aibokin ijo aipara ka ateker" —

the one who knows the old ways is never lost — they mean that language and story are the most durable records we have. The game survived because a poet remembered it.

Regional Varieties and Modern Bao

As Bao spread through East Africa, it differentiated into distinct forms, each carrying the character of its community — just as the Iteso of Uganda and Kenya share common roots but have developed different paths due to geography, history, and the communities around them.

Bao la Kiswahili

The full, grandmaster version played in Zanzibar, Dar es Salaam, and coastal Tanzania. This is the most complex — the chess of the mancala world.

Bao la Kujifunza

"Bao for learners" — a simplified form with fewer capturing rules, used to introduce children and newcomers to the game's philosophy and spirit.

Bawo

The Malawian variant — the oldest surviving physical board (1896, now in the British Museum). Minor rule differences, but the same four-row, eight-pit architecture.

Omweso

The Ugandan relative, played on a 4×8 board with different capture mechanics — beloved in Buganda and increasingly popular in regional tournaments.

In 1966, the *Chama cha Bao* (Bao Society) was formed in Tanzania to preserve, standardise, and promote the game. It awards the title of *Bingwa* — master — to its finest players. Today, Bao is played daily in village *barazas* (gathering places) and is recognised as an intangible cultural heritage of the Swahili people.

How to Play Bao

Bao is a two-player game of sowing and capturing on a 4×8 board. Each player controls the two rows nearest them. Seeds are sown by picking up all seeds from one pit and distributing them one by one into successive pits moving anti-clockwise.

The Basics of Bao la Kiswahili

- 1 Namua phase (Setup):** Players alternate placing 2 seeds at a time onto their back row. During Namua, a player must capture if possible — and capturing continues the Namua sequence.
- 2 Sowing:** Pick up all seeds from any of your pits and sow them one by one into successive pits, moving anti-clockwise. The last seed sown determines what happens next.

3

Capturing: If the last seed lands in an occupied pit in your front row that is directly opposite an occupied pit in your opponent's front row, you capture those opponent seeds and continue sowing from the capture pit.

4

The Nyumba (house): During Namua, if a player sows 3 seeds into a pit that already has some, they may "build a house." The Nyumba has special tactical protections and serves as a renewable seed base.

5

Winning: A player wins when their opponent has fewer than 2 seeds in their front row and cannot make a valid capture — or is completely unable to move.

S TRATEGIES

Build Your Nyumba Early

A well-positioned Nyumba acts as a renewable seed source. Experienced players plan their entire Namua phase around securing the best house position.

Control the Inner Pits

The inner four pits of your front row are strategic gold. Concentrate seeds there and starve your opponent's inner row simultaneously.

Force Unfavourable Captures

Since capturing is mandatory, you can force your opponent into bad captures by engineering positions where their only options lead them into a trap on your next turn.

Distribute, Don't Hoard

A player with seeds spread evenly is flexible. One with seeds hoarded in a single pit is vulnerable. Like the Iteso clan system — one powerful clan alone is more fragile than many smaller ones working in concert.

1966 – PRESENT



Chama cha Bao

The Tanzanian Bao Society — the organising body that awards the Bingwa (master) title and runs tournaments across the Swahili coast.

1979



Philip Townshend

British academic whose doctoral thesis provided the most rigorous analysis of Bao's rules and social role — the As-Suli of Bao scholarship.

EARLY 1800S



Muyaka bin Haji

Mombasa's greatest Swahili poet, who immortalised Bao in verse — ensuring the game's specific vocabulary survived in literature before any scholar documented it.

PART THREE

Ajua

The Luo Game of Seeds — prestige, cattle, and the lake shore

Ajua — The Luo Game of Seeds

If Bao is the grandmaster — cerebral, elaborate, ceremonial — then Ajua is the warrior: urgent, competitive, played hard and played for stakes. Ajua (also spelled Ajwaa) is the name given to mancala games by the Luo, Luhya, Samburu, and Turkana peoples of western Kenya and eastern Uganda. The name comes from the Luo language — possibly derived from the seeds traditionally used as playing pieces.

Played on a 2×8 or 2×10 board — two rows of eight or ten pits — Ajua is less complex in its capturing mechanics than Bao, but fiercer in its social context. It was, and in many places still is, a gambling game. The stakes were cattle, goats, and money. Chiefs used it to settle minor disputes instead of adjudication. Herdsmen played it while watching their herds under an open sky — the board sometimes carved directly into the earth at their feet.

Cattle and Stakes

The Iteso, like the Luo, measured wealth in cattle. Bridewealth negotiations were conducted with sticks representing cows; the actual cattle were brought only after agreement was reached. That Ajua was played for cattle stakes is not surprising — across the Lake Victoria basin, cattle were the primary currency of prestige and social relationship. A game of Ajua was not merely entertainment. It was an economic and social event, as consequential as a market day or a council meeting.

C H A P T E R · Fourteen

Early Historical Records and Cultural Role

1929

The first written description of Ajua appears in George R. Carline's travel writings on East Africa — men playing in cattle camps, pits carved directly into the ground.

1965

Kenyan historian John N. B. Osogo provides the most detailed early account of Ajua among the Luo — the board (*kido*), the seeds (*go* or *ajua*), and the gambling culture surrounding competitive play.

June 27, 1977

The **Kenya Ajua Club** is officially registered in Nairobi — the first formal organisation dedicated to Ajua as a recognised traditional sport.

2005

Kenya's Sports Ministry officially recognises Ajua as a traditional sport — it may now be played in national school competitions.

2008

The first Ajua tournament outside Africa is held at the Kenya American Day celebration in Jersey City, New Jersey.

2021

Nairobi-based Rubik's Digital launches Ajua on their PlayOn e-sports platform — Android and iOS, with online multiplayer and ranked matches.



2023

The first online Ajua tournament draws players from Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania, and the Kenyan diaspora in the USA and UK.

The Question of Gender

Ajua was traditionally a man's game — herdsman's game, warrior's game, elder's game. Women were excluded not because of incapacity but because the game was embedded in masculine institutions: the cattle camp, the gambling circle, the elder's court of arbitration. This pattern has been relaxing in recent decades, particularly in urban areas and school competitions.

The Iteso have their own gendered cultural traditions — yet the Iteso also know that traditions evolve. Culture is not a cage. It is a living, breathing conversation between generations.

How to Play Ajua

THE AJUA BOARD — 2 ROWS × 8 PITS

Each player controls one row · 4 seeds per pit at the start

Ajua is played on a 2×8 board — two rows of eight pits.

Each player controls one row. Seeds are distributed in the pits at the start; the aim is to capture more seeds than your opponent and eventually leave them unable to move.

Setup and Play

1

Setup: Place 4 seeds in each of the 16 pits (2×8 board) — 64 seeds total. Each player controls the 8 pits in their single row.

2

Sowing: On your turn, pick up all seeds from any of your pits and sow them one by one into successive pits, moving in either direction — you choose direction at the start of the move and maintain it.

3

Capturing: If your last seed is dropped into a pit directly opposite an occupied pit in your opponent's row, you capture all seeds in that opposing pit. Captured seeds go to your store.

4

Continuing: If the last seed lands in an already-occupied pit in your own row and no capture occurs, pick up all seeds in that pit (including the one just placed) and continue sowing.

5

Ending: A player who cannot make a move (all pits empty or holding only one seed) loses. The player with more captured seeds wins if both sides still have moves remaining.

S TRATEGIES

Directional Control

The choice of direction for each sow is crucial. Experienced players plan two and three moves ahead, choosing directions that set up future captures while blocking immediate threats.

Concentrate Your Seeds

Rather than spreading seeds thinly, concentrate them to create large sowing chains that can sweep across the board and produce multiple captures in a single turn.

Opponent Starvation

The primary winning condition is leaving your opponent unable to move. Methodically drain their pits while maintaining your own seed supply. This requires the patience the Iteso call forbearance.

Trap and Sacrifice

Sacrifice smaller pits to draw your opponent into a position where their capturing move leads them into a larger counter-capture on your next turn — the same principle as a chess fork, played with seeds.

FOUNDED 1977



Kenya Ajua Association

The governing body for competitive Ajua — setting rules, organising national tournaments, certifying referees, and running the ranking system since 2020.

1965



John N. B. Osogo

Kenyan historian who produced the first serious academic documentation of Ajua among the Luo — the game's earliest true chronicler in writing.

2021



Rubik's Digital

The Nairobi gaming studio that brought Ajua to smartphone screens worldwide — online multiplayer, ranked matches, tutorials. The game now lives in every pocket.

PART FOUR

The Game of Life

A chess set made for H.E. — by Lidong'a, Osier & Ilejje



Chess is not merely a contest of kings and pawns. It is a mirror of existence. Every move is a choice, every capture a consequence, every check a test of nerve. In this board, we see our struggles, our relationships, and our aspirations.

"When you sit before this board, you are not playing a game. You are walking through your own life."

We have taken the ancient game and breathed into it a new soul. The pieces are no longer abstract soldiers. They become the people you love and the virtues you strive to live by.

The **black pieces** represent Henry's world — his family, his closest allies, the faces that give him ground to stand on. The **white pieces** represent the virtues and traits that guide him — the inner compass that points toward a life well lived.

Black (top) — Henry's family and friends · White (bottom) — Virtues and traits

C H A P T E R · S e v e n t e e n

The Black Pieces — Henry's World



Henry's World

Friends, family, and the people who give him ground to stand on



KING

Henry

The anchor. The centre of this universe. Without him, the game ends. He is the core around whom all else turns — protected at all costs, irreplaceable, and the measure by which every other piece's purpose is judged.



QUEEN

Vivian

His closest ally. She moves with grace and power across the board, through any challenge. She is the partner who amplifies his strength — the most powerful force in his world — and the one who walks beside him in every direction without hesitation.



BISHOP · KINGSIDE

Chloe

His baby niece. Bishops move diagonally — through the unexpected paths. Children see what adults overlook; their innocence guides from angles we forget. Chloe is the purity of heart he sees in all of humanity.



BISHOP · QUEENSIDE

Anita

His daughter. The two bishops together cover all squares the other cannot reach. Anita and Chloe together make certain that no part of Henry's life goes unguarded by love's most honest form.



KNIGHT · KINGSIDE

Nick

His son. Knights leap over obstacles, turning corners, appearing where least expected. Nick would ride at dawn should the need arise — loyal, daring, and always ready when it matters most.



KNIGHT · QUEENSIDE

Luther

His son. Together, Nick and Luther are the dawn-riders — the sons who come at the first call, who leap where pawns cannot go, and who make moves nobody else on the board can make.



ROOK · KINGSIDE

M. Nyangabiyaki

His old high school mate. The rook holds the flank without drama — straight lines, unwavering presence. The friend who has stood with Henry since youth, through victories and defeats, requiring nothing but the act of showing up.



ROOK · QUEENSIDE

P. Nyangabiyaki

His other lifelong ally from school days. The second rook, guarding the other flank of the king's world. Together, the two Nyangabiyakis are the architectural pillars without which the whole structure cannot stand.

The Pawns — His Siblings

Pawns are the daily presence — the backbone of the army. They move steadily, one step at a time, but they are the ones who hold the line. And when a pawn reaches the far end of the board, it becomes a queen. That is family: ordinary, steady, and capable of extraordinary transformation.



Tom

The eldest — the first one forward, always.



Hope

The name says everything that needs saying.



Martha

Steadfast and grounded — unmoved by storms.



Aloni

Present and loyal — stands beside Luther always.



Siobhance

The youngest named — far in age, close in heart.

Beateu

Quiet strength — the kind that outlasts noise.



Ernest

Dependable and true — stands beside Nick always.



The Eighth

Still becoming — the one they all look back for.

C H A P T E R · Eighteen

The White Pieces — Virtues & Traits



Virtues & Traits

The ideals — the inner compass that points toward a life well lived



KING

Honesty / Integrity

The master virtue. Without honesty, no other virtue stands. In chess, if the king falls, you lose. If you lose integrity, you lose yourself. This is the non-negotiable core — the virtue all others exist to protect.



QUEEN

Empathy & Humility

The most powerful piece on the board. True power is not domination — it is understanding (empathy) and the refusal to boast (humility). She moves everywhere, but she never forgets that others also move.



BISHOP · KINGSIDE

Wisdom

Wisdom sees what is not straight ahead. The diagonal path — the long view, the quiet counsel from an unexpected angle. Wisdom is Chloe and Anita's purity, grown into patient adulthood.



BISHOP · QUEENSIDE

Patience

Patience waits for the right angle. It does not rush. In a world of speed, patience is the bishop that controls the far squares years before they are needed — as the Iteso Apolon ka Ateker held his tongue until the moment was right.



KNIGHT · KINGSIDE

Courage

Courage leaps over fear. When the board is crowded, the knight jumps. When danger blocks the way, courage finds the unexpected route. The Ikaribwok did not wait for the path to clear — they cleared it themselves.



KNIGHT · QUEENSIDE

Determination

Determination refuses to give up. Two steps one way, one step the other — always advancing, never in a straight line, but always forward. This is the grit that finishes what courage starts.



ROOK · KINGSIDE

Loyalty

Loyalty is the straight line of the rook — it does not waver, does not bend, does not seek a clever angle. It protects the king's flank without question, without complaint, without seeking credit.



ROOK · QUEENSIDE

Justice

Justice sees all ranks equally. From the first rank to the eighth, from pawn to queen — fairness applies to everyone. The rook's straight line is the law without favour. The Apolon ka Ateker was chosen for exactly this: impartiality.

The White Pawns — Ten Small Virtues

The pawns are the daily habits. They do not seem mighty — but push one to the end of the board, and it becomes a queen. Practise these small virtues every day, and they build the life that the great virtues merely describe.



Truthfulness

Guards the King — speaks plainly and without fear.



Compassion

Guards the Queen — feels before it speaks or acts.



Reflection

Guards Wisdom — pauses before moving forward.



Forbearance

Guards Patience — holds its ground and waits well.



Bravery

Guards Courage — moves first, even into the unknown.



Perseverance

Guards Determination — never retreats a single step.



Kindness

Left flank — small daily acts, freely and quietly given.



Gratitude

Left flank — receives each day as an unearned gift.



Generosity

Right flank — gives without keeping score or record.



Hopefulness

Right flank — always the very last pawn standing.

Play Well. Live Well.

This is your board now. When you move Henry, you are protecting your anchor. When you move Vivian, you honour your closest ally. When you advance Tom or Hope, you walk with your siblings. And on the other side, when you slide Honesty forward or leap with Courage, you are choosing who you want to become.

The Iteso say that the one who knows the old ways is never lost. Chess came from a king's court in ancient India. Bao grew from seeds pressed into the earth of Africa for seven thousand years. Ajua was played between herdsmen who wagered their cattle on a game of pure strategy under an open sky. All three arrived at the same truth: how you play says who you are.

The game of chess, the sowing of Bao and Ajua — they are all the same story. Strategy, patience, love, and principle.

The Ikaribwok warrior who knew when to fight. The Apolon ka Ateker elected for neutrality and wisdom at the Airukorin ceremony. The Emorimor who stands in leopard-skin robes knowing that his authority comes not from force but from the trust of his people.

Every move you make on this board is a move you make in your life.



THIS BOOK WAS PREPARED FOR H.E.

BY LIDONG'A, OSIER AND ILEJJE

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WRITTEN IN THE SPIRIT OF THE ITESO PEOPLE
OF EASTERN UGANDA AND WESTERN KENYA